



YOUR FIRST DAY IN RUSSIA: FROM LANDING TO TASTING YOUR FIRST BORSCHT

1. **Exchange money at the airport.**
2. **Get a SIM card.**
3. **Must-have apps for life in Russia.**
4. **Greetings & Polite Stuff.**
5. **Shopping & Food Ordering Phrases.**
6. **Asking for Help & Navigation.**
7. **Emergency and Safety Phrases.**

Currency Exchange at the Airport

When you arrive in Russia, first thing you have to do is to exchange your **бабки** (bap-ki —money, slang) to Russian Rubles (rub-li) .

Currency exchange desks are available at airports, but rates may not be the best.

Exchange a bit of money at the airport — around \$200 should be enough to get to your hotel and grab something to eat. You can exchange the rest once you're in the city.



Где обмен валюты?

Gde ab-men va-lyu-ty?

Where is the currency exchange?



Хочу поменять 100/200 долларов.

Ha-chu pa-me-nyat' sto/dve-sti dol-la-raf.

I want to exchange \$100/200.



Сколько комиссия?

Skol'-ka ka-mis-si-ya?

How much is the commission?



Дайте чек, пожалуйста.

Day-te chek, pa-zha-lu-sta.

Please give me a receipt.

Buying a SIM Card

📌 Important: New Russian SIM Card Restrictions (Effective January 1, 2025)

Recent legislation has significantly complicated SIM card acquisition for foreign citizens. Tourists without Russian language skills will find the process extremely challenging, often leading to giving up mid-way.

Helpful Tip: If you're travelling to Russia short term, your **BEST OPTION** is:

If you have a Russian friend or contact, they can register a SIM card under their name and let you use it.

Discuss roaming options with your local provider.

Some small kiosks at the airport may still offer SIM cards that are not registered in your name.

🇷🇺 Getting a SIM Card in Russia (2025) What You Need

- **Passport** (+ visa or migration card, if applicable) – for identity verification.
- **SNILS** – Russian social insurance number (can be obtained at any *MFC* public service center if you stay long-term).
- **Verified Gosuslugi account** – register at gosuslugi.ru using your passport details.
- **Biometrics (photo + fingerprints)** – register once at a bank or official service center; they'll upload it to the Unified Biometric System.
- **Phone IMEI** – dial *#06# to find it.

📄 Step-by-Step

1. Register your **biometrics** and link your **SNILS + Gosuslugi** account at a bank or service center.
2. Go to a **mobile operator's store** (MTS, Beeline, Megafon, Tele2).
3. Present your documents and IMEI, **sign the contract**, and get your SIM card activated.



MTS



Beeline



Megafon

Essential Apps for Travel and Life in Russia



Yandex Go

For taxis and navigation (like Uber).



Yandex Maps

For public transport and directions.

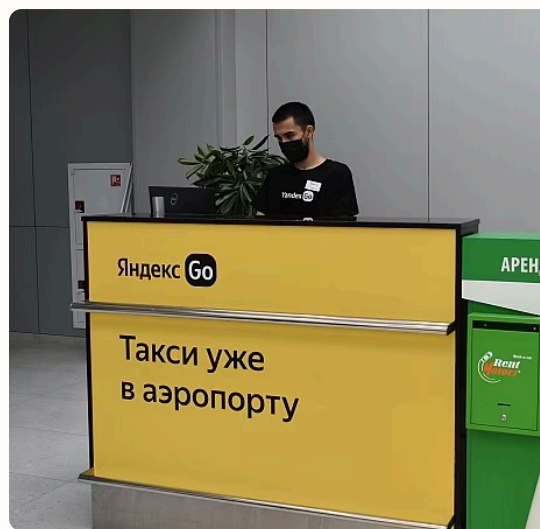


Yandex Translate

For translating Russian on the go.

📌 Top tip: Download these apps before your trip. Yandex Maps and Yandex Translate both have offline modes.

Find a taxi booking counter (Yandex Go)



Alternative Transportation Options:

- If you can't find Yandex Go desk, ask airport **information desk** staff to help call a taxi (they speak English)

Important preparation tips:

- Keep your hotel's address written in Russian and English
- Download translation apps with offline mode before arrival

It's better to choose a hotel that offers airport transfer so you get the instructions in advance on how and where to go.

Basic Greetings and Politeness

Learning basic greetings and polite phrases is essential for making a great first impression in Russia. Locals appreciate the effort, leading to friendlier interactions and helping you connect confidently.



Здравствуйте!

Zdra-stvuy-te!

Hello! (formal)



Привет!

Pri-vet!

Hi! (informal)



Как дела?

Kak de-la?

How are you?



Спасибо большое!

Spa-si-ba bal'-sho-ye!

Thank you very much!



Пожалуйста.

Pa-zha-lu-sta.

You're welcome.



Очень приятно!

O-chen' pri-yat-na!

Nice to meet you!



Извините, пожалуйста.

Iz-vi-ni-te, pa-zha-lu-sta.

Excuse me, please.



Простите за беспокойство.

Pras-ti-te za bes-pa-koy-stva.

Sorry for the trouble.

Доброе утро!

Dob-ra-ye ut-ra! – Good morning!

Добрый вечер!

Dob-ryy vecher! – Good evening!

С удовольствием.

S u-da-vol'-stvi-yem. – With pleasure.

До свидания!

Da svi-da-ni-ya! – Goodbye!

Всего хорошего!

Fse-vo kha-ro-she-va! – All the best!

Хорошего дня!

Kha-ro-she-va dnya!

Have a good day!



Shopping and Dining Phrases

These phrases are essential for smooth interactions in Russian restaurants and shops, and your effort to use them will be appreciated.



Меню, пожалуйста

Mozh-na me-nyu, pa-zha-lu-sta?

Can I have the menu, please?



У вас есть...?

U vas est'...?

Do you have...?

- борщ (*borsch*) – borscht
- голубцы (*ga-lub-tsy*) – stuffed cabbage
- пельмени (*pel'-me-ni*) – dumplings
- блины (*bli-ny*) – pancakes
- котлеты (*kat-le-ty*) – cutlets
- салат Оливье (*sa-lat A-li-vye*) – Olivier salad



Можно без...?

Mozh-na bez...?

Can I have it without...?

- без лука (*bez lu-ka*) – without onions
- без мяса (*bez mya-sa*) – without meat
- без чеснока (*bez ches-na-ka*) – without garlic
- без молока (*bez ma-la-ka*) – without milk
- без орехов (*bez a-re-khav*) – without nuts



Это...?

Eta...?

Is this...?

- острое (*os-tra-ye*) – spicy
- сладкое (*slat-ka-ye*) – sweet
- солёное (*sa-lyo-na-ye*) – salty
- кислое (*kis-la-ye*) – sour



Сколько это стоит?

Skol'-ka eta sto-it?

How much is this?

More Dining Phrases



Я хочу это.

Ya kha-chu eta.

I want this.



Где касса?

Gde kas-sa?

Where is the cashier?



Можно оплатить...?

Mozh-na ap-la-tit'...?

Can I pay...?

- картой (*kar-tay*) – by card
- наличкой (*na-lich-kai*) – with cash



Я забронировал столик.

Ya za-bra-ni-ra-val sto-lik.

I have a reservation.



Счёт, пожалуйста.

Schet, pa-zha-lu-sta.

The bill, please.

How to Ask for Help and Directions

When you need help or directions, these phrases will be invaluable. Russians are generally responsive to tourists who try to communicate in Russian, so don't hesitate to ask for help.



Помогите, пожалуйста.

Pa-ma-gi-te, pa-zha-lu-sta.

Help me, please.



Я не понимаю.

Ya ne pa-ni-ma-yu.

I don't understand.



Говорите медленнее,
пожалуйста.

*Ga-va-ri-te med-len-ne-ye, pa-
zha-lu-sta.*

Speak slower, please.

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Я плохо говорю по-русски.

Ya plo-ha ga-va-ryu pa rus-ski.

I speak Russian badly.

Direction Questions

- **Где...?** (*Gde...?*) – Where is...?
 - туалет (*tu-a-let*) – toilet
 - банкомат (*ban-ka-mat*) – ATM
 - супермаркет (*su-per-mar-ket*) – supermarket
 - аптека (*ap-te-ka*) – pharmacy
 - метро (*met-ro*) – metro
 - вокзал (*vak-zal*) – train station
 - автобусная остановка (*af-to-bus-na-ya as-ta-nof-ka*) – bus stop
 - отель (*a-tel'*) – hotel
 - ресторан (*res-ta-ran*) – restaurant
 - музей (*mu-zey*) – museum



Transportation and Navigation

These phrases will help you navigate public transport and taxi services.



Metro and Public Transport

- **Где метро?**
(*Gde met-ro?*) Where is the metro?
- **Сколько стоит билет?**
(*Skol'-ka sto-it bi-let?*) How much is a ticket?
- **Эта станция...?**
(*Eta stan-tsi-ya...?*) Is this station...?



Taxi Services

- **Вызовите такси, пожалуйста.**
(*Vy-za-vi-te tak-si, pa-zha-lu-sta.*) Call a taxi, please.
- **Сколько будет стоить?**
(*Skol'-ka bu-det sto-it'?*) How much will it cost?
- **Остановите здесь.** (*As-ta-na-vi-te zdes'.*) Stop here.



Bus and Tram

- **Когда приедет автобус?**
(*Ka-gda pri-ye-det af-to-bus?*) When will the bus arrive?
- **Этот автобус идёт в центр?**
(*E-tot av-to-bus i-dyot f tsentr?*) Does this bus go downtown?

Emergency and Safety Phrases

While Russia is generally safe for tourists, it's important to know emergency phrases. Keep emergency numbers saved in your phone and know these key phrases that could be crucial in urgent situations.



Emergency Numbers

- **112** – Universal emergency
- **101** – Fire department
- **102** – Police
- **103** – Ambulance



Key Emergency Phrases

- **Помогите!**
(*Pa-ma-gi-te!*)
Help!
- **Вызовите скорую!**
(*Vy-za-vi-te sko-ru-yu!*) Call an ambulance!
- **Где больница?**
(*Gde bal'-ni-tsa?*)
Where is the hospital?



Personal Safety

- **Я потерялся.**
(*Ya pa-te-ryal-sya.*)
I am lost.
- **Где посольство?**
(*Gde pa-sol'-stva?*)
Where is the embassy?
- **Мне нужен врач.**
(*Mne nu-zhen vrach.*)
I need a doctor.

Important: Always carry a copy of your passport and visa. Keep originals in your hotel safe. Russian police may ask for identification, and having copies prevents losing your original documents.

[Emergency and safety phrases.m4a](#)



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